

## The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

After several attempts to reach anyone at the bank with the authority to work out a mutually satisfactory settlement, I finally contacted the bank president. When I promised that we would oversee the debt repayment, he agreed to a monthly payment that was within reason.

This man and his wife faithfully stuck to their commitment, and after two years of paying \$25 a month on a \$3,000 debt, they still owed \$2,880 after interest was deducted. But the bank president elected to forgive all the interest and write off half of the original debt, and in six more months they were free of the debt entirely. The lesson that Scripture teaches on this principle is found in Proverbs 15:19: "The way of the sluggard is a hedge of thorns, but the path of the upright is a highway."

### DANGER SIGN: RELIGIOUS ESCAPE

A religious experience occurs when someone having great problems seeks to escape by falling back on religious clichés, such as "I'm trusting God to provide." Obviously, each of us is to trust God, but if our bad habits have created the circumstances, God wants those changed first. We are to be participants in God's plan, not observers.

God does provide; everything we have comes from Him. But He also directs us to use our abilities and to be responsible for our actions. When one turns to God for help, more responsibility is expected, not less. "And if you have not been faithful in the use of that which is another's, who will give you that which is your own?" (Luke 16:12)

Dave was experiencing some significant financial problems due to business setbacks. In reality, his problems were not so much due to personal mistakes as they were to changes in the tax laws that affected his particular business. But as the business deteriorated, Dave continued to maintain his lifestyle and his giving at the previous level. The income from his business dropped to where creditors weren't getting paid on time, some not at all. When he was challenged by a friend who knew his circumstances, he responded that to lessen his giving (which